meant. I informed him that I played cricket for Yorkshire and it was a car given to me by the county. At this he asked my name and queried if I was indeed the first overseas professional to play for Yorkshire. I think it was my identity that earned me a reprieve and I was let off with a warning that I should always keep the speed limit in mind while driving.

Life lessons

At Yorkshire we often played back-to-back matches and it helped me improve my batting a great deal. The conditions were very different from those back home and I definitely matured as a batsman during my time in county cricket. The ball would swing a greal deal more than in India and it allowed me to improve my technique and ability to adjust to different conditions. Over the years, the lessons learnt from my stint at Yorkshire continued to help me whenever I toured England as part of the Indian team.

Socially too it was a good learning experience. The authorities, including the president Sir Lawrence Byford, were extremely sociable. The team had a great time and I particularly remember some extremely interesting Sunday club bonding sessions. In one it was decided that everybody had to wear towels and a tie without a shirt and meet in the hotel's convention centre. At first I thought my team-mates were pulling my leg and I wasn't prepared to dress up without seeing a few of the other players do so. I kept a close eye on the lobby and only when I saw a number of my team-mates sporting a towel and tie did I do the same. It turned out to be an eccentric but hilarious evening in the end.

Everyone at Yorkshire knew I was only nineteen and they were always eager to help. This was just as well, because things were not at all what I was used to in Mumbai. I had toured England in 1990, of course, but back then I had been with the Indian team and everything was arranged for us. This time I had to do everything on my own – from organizing my own food to doing the laundry.

Coping by myself sometimes caused me great embarrassment. One incident involved my first attempt to use a washing machine. I had no idea how much detergent was needed and must have emptied about half a packet into the machine before starting the washing cycle, then I went out. On my way back I could see something oozing beneath my front door. I was shocked at first until I remembered that I had left the washing